Disability-Compensatory Generative AI Use: From Restored Dignity to the Guardrail Paradox, Toward Disability-Inclusive AI Design

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ABSTRACT: My dissertation research investigates how blind and visually impaired people use generative AI (GenAI) as a disability-compensatory tool, and how AI system design simultaneously enables and structurally undermines that use. The research builds on three interlocking qualitative studies with blind university students in South Korea, one of the world's most intensive GenAI adoption contexts. The first study, published in Korea's leading social welfare journal, introduced and operationalized the concept of Disability-Compensatory GenAI Use. The second study, currently under review, demonstrated that such use restructures the relational and existential conditions of everyday independence, culminating in participants' accounts of restored human dignity. The third and current study theorizes the Guardrail Paradox by Disability Decontextualization: the structural mechanism through which AI safety guardrails, designed to protect users, produce compounded harm for blind users by simultaneously under-incorporating disability context, blocking legitimate requests and forcing greater privacy exposure, and over-incorporating it, generating paternalistic interactions and distorted outputs after disability disclosure or recognition. The remaining dissertation work integrates these findings into a unified theoretical framework and translates it into principles for disability-inclusive AI design. I seek the Doctoral Consortium's mentorship at this integrative stage of my research.

CCS CONCEPTS • Human-centered computing → Accessibility → Accessibility systems and tools • Human-centered computing → Accessibility → Empirical studies in accessibility • Computing methodologies → Artificial intelligence → Natural language

processing • Social and professional topics → User characteristics → People with disabilities

Additional Keywords and Phrases: generative AI; visual impairment; disability-compensatory GenAI use; AI safety guardrails; disability decontextualization; algorithmic othering; human dignity; inclusive AI design

1. Problem and Motivation

The daily information ecology of blind and visually impaired people has historically been structured around a fundamental asymmetry: sighted people access visual information instantaneously and independently, whereas blind people must request, await, and depend on human intermediaries to access the same information. Reading a financial document, checking the state of one's clothing, identifying a person in a photograph — each of these routine acts has required the mediation of sighted others. This dependency is not a neutral functional limitation. It carries what prior research has termed a relational cost: psychological indebtedness toward helpers, involuntary exposure of private information, temporal dependency on others' availability, and the cumulative erosion of autonomous selfhood [1].

Multimodal generative AI has arrived in blind people's lives as a technology that promises to dissolve this asymmetry. Capable of interpreting images, generating contextual descriptions, and engaging in open-ended dialogue, GenAI offers a non-judgmental, instantly available channel through which visual information can be accessed without social obligation [2, 1]. South Korea provides a particularly revealing context in which to study this transformation: 63.5% of the national workforce reports GenAI use, more than twice the rate observed in the United States, and the country ranks second globally in per-capita ChatGPT spending [3, 4]. Korean blind users are therefore not early adopters experimenting with a novelty but experienced users who have already woven GenAI into the fabric of daily life.

A growing international literature has begun to document this use. Adnin and Das [5] showed that blind users employ GenAI for information retrieval and image description; Tang et al. [2] conceptualized the persistent doubt accompanying AI outputs as ‘everyday uncertainty’; Sharma et al. [1] demonstrated that blind users increasingly prefer GenAI over human assistance for sensitive visual information precisely because it preserves privacy autonomy; Atcheson et al. [6] documented students with disabilities using GenAI to strengthen self-advocacy. These studies represent important empirical advances, yet they remain predominantly functional accounts: what tasks GenAI enables, what errors it produces, and how users work around its limits.

What remains largely unexamined is the structural relationship between disabled users’ agency and AI system design itself — above all, the design of AI safety guardrails. Guardrails are the technical constraints built into GenAI systems to prevent harmful, deceptive, or privacy-violating outputs [7, 8]. For blind users who rely on GenAI as a disability-compensatory tool, these guardrails do not function as neutral safety mechanisms. When a blind user asks GenAI to read a credit card number from a photograph, to check clothing for menstrual staining, or to describe friends’ appearance in social photographs, the system classifies the request as a privacy or sensitivity risk and refuses — without recognizing that these are precisely the categories of information that blind users cannot access through vision, and that the request is not a privacy violation but a disability-compensatory necessity. Critical scholarship suggests this is no accident: disability is systematically misrepresented in training data [9], AI systems position disability-associated patterns as deviant without explicit awareness of disability [10], and development cultures exclude disabled people from design and testing — an ‘exclusion by design’ [11].

Three gaps in the literature motivate my research. First, while guardrail-related access restrictions have been empirically reported [2, 1], the structural mechanism through which safety design produces harm for disabled users has not been theorized; existing work documents the symptom but not the logic that generates it. Second, the system’s opposite failure — paternalistic, pitying, and distorted responses after disability is disclosed or recognized — has been noted only in passing, and the coexistence of both failures within

the same system has not, to my knowledge, been analyzed as a single structural phenomenon. Third, the field lacks an account that connects these design failures to what is actually at stake for users: not convenience, but independence, privacy autonomy, and human dignity. Addressing this last gap requires grounding the analysis in disabled users' own accounts of what GenAI means in their lives, which is where my research began.

The overarching question guiding my dissertation is therefore threefold: how does Disability-Compensatory GenAI Use restructure the conditions of blind people's daily lives; through what structural mechanisms does AI system design simultaneously enable and undermine that use; and what would AI design that treats disabled users as equal informational agents — rather than objects of protection — require?

This question carries weight beyond its immediate population. If guardrails systematically fail blind users by stripping disability context from their requests, the same logic plausibly affects any user group whose legitimate needs diverge from the design-imagined default user. And because the stakes the research documents — privacy autonomy, independence, dignity — are core concerns of social work as a discipline, the dissertation also aims to build a bridge that the literature currently lacks: between the accessibility community's design knowledge and social work's rights-based, structural analysis of disability. My position as a blind screen reader user and doctoral researcher in social work places me, by training and by lived experience, at exactly this intersection.

2. Research Trajectory: Three Interlocking Studies

My dissertation research has developed through three interlocking qualitative studies, each deepening a question opened by the previous one. The three studies form a single program of qualitative inquiry with the same cohort of seven blind university students in South Korea, and draw on a layered data corpus. Study 1 analyzed focus group interview transcripts (three sessions, 90–120 minutes each). Study 2 reanalyzed those transcripts with a distinct analytic focus on everyday life beyond academia, and incorporated supplementary asynchronous written responses collected from the same participants on topics outside the scope of Study 1. Study 3 draws on the focus group transcripts and collected a further round of asynchronous data specifically addressing guardrail

experiences, which had emerged as a distinct research question through the earlier analyses. All three studies were conducted under a single IRB approval (Ewha Womans University IRB, Approval No. ewha-202602-0016-01) that encompassed the full research program, including the possibility of supplementary data collection with the same participants on expanded topics.

Study 1 — conceptualizing the phenomenon (published). The first study, published in the Korean Journal of Social Welfare, Korea's leading social welfare journal [12], explored how blind university students use GenAI in academic performance. Building on Morris's [13] account of AI-augmented accessibility, it characterized GenAI-Augmented Accessibility — the state in which information can be instantly reconstructed across modalities once that notion is extended to generative AI. On this foundation, the study developed its central conceptual contribution: Disability-Compensatory GenAI Use, which I operationalized by drawing on the compensation principle of Baltes and Baltes' [14] SOC model and the learning agency emphasized in Zimmerman's [15] self-regulated learning — fitting for a study of academic performance — to name the agentive strategies through which disabled users actively compensate for the sensory, physical, and structural constraints imposed by inaccessible environments, thereby recovering the learning agency that those environments had displaced. Crucially, what is compensated for is not the disabled body but the ableist-designed environment, aligning the concept with the social model of disability. To my knowledge, it was among the first Korean empirical accounts of blind people's GenAI use, and it surfaced two findings that seeded everything that followed: participants reported GenAI outputs skewed toward socially preferred, over-positive answers, and a continuous 'secondary-verification burden' [2] unique to users who cannot visually cross-check outputs. It also identified its own boundary: academic performance was only one arena, and the study called for extending the inquiry into everyday life.

Study 2 — establishing what is at stake (under review). The second study, currently under review, answered that call by examining GenAI in participants' daily lives beyond academic settings. Interpreted through the Capability Approach [16, 17], empowerment theory [18], and Jacobson's [19] framework of dignity, the findings showed that GenAI

negates the relational cost of help-seeking, enables users to cross previously impassable thresholds such as creating visual content and travelling abroad without sighted companions, and converges into a restored sense of personhood — captured in one participant's words, 'I finally feel like a person.' The study also identified disability self-disclosure to AI as a novel site of identity negotiation: some participants strategically disclosed their disability to optimize outputs, while others withheld it to be treated as 'just an ordinary person.' That finding raised the question the current study confronts directly: if users must manage when and how the system knows about their disability, what is the system doing with disability context in the first place?

Study 3 — theorizing the structural mechanism (current; detailed in Section 3). The third study, whose manuscript is in preparation for submission, answers that question by theorizing how AI safety design handles — and mishandles — disability context. It is the conceptual core of the dissertation: where Study 1 named the practice and Study 2 established its stakes, Study 3 identifies the structural mechanism by which current AI design undermines both.

3. Current Study: The Guardrail Paradox by Disability Decontextualization

3.1 Conceptual Framing

The study sits at the intersection of three bodies of scholarship. From critical algorithm studies, it takes the insight that algorithmic exclusion is structural rather than accidental: AI systems encode and amplify existing social hierarchies [20, 21], and disability is distinctively vulnerable because its heterogeneity defies the statistical logic of machine learning [9]. From critical disability studies, it takes the genealogy of the tragedy model [22, 23] and its technological reproduction as technoableism [24]: when systems learn from data saturated with ableist assumptions and are tuned by human raters inhabiting an ableist society — for instance through reinforcement learning from human feedback [25] — the construction of disability as deficit is not eliminated but encoded, producing the algorithmic othering documented by Whittaker et al. [10]. From information ethics, it takes Nissenbaum's [26] theory of contextual integrity, which locates privacy violations not in

information's inherent sensitivity but in the disruption of context-appropriate information flows, together with accounts of information access as a substantive right and capability-sensitive resource [27, 28].

The pivotal analytic concept is Disability Decontextualization: the failure of AI systems to recognize the distinctive context in which blind users make information requests. A request that sighted users would never need to make — because they can simply see — is evaluated by the guardrail as if made by a sighted requester, and is therefore misclassified as risk. The information withheld is not inherently sensitive; it is classified as risk by a system that cannot perceive the disability-compensatory context that makes the request legitimate. Disability Decontextualization is, in Nissenbaum's terms, a systematic violation of contextual integrity built into safety architecture itself.

This framing also reveals why guardrail blocking constitutes more than an access failure. Mathiesen [28] conceptualizes information access as a capability-sensitive resource that is realized only when information is findable, reachable, comprehensible, and usable — dimensions that are mutually constitutive rather than sequential. When a guardrail refuses a blind user's request, it forecloses an entire modality of access across all four dimensions at once. And because blind users turned to GenAI precisely to avoid disclosing private matters to other people, the refusal compounds: it pushes them back toward human intermediaries, compelling a wider and more socially burdensome privacy exposure than the one the guardrail was designed to prevent. The violation of informational justice and the violation of contextual integrity occur simultaneously, through the same design decision.

3.2 Research Questions

RQ1. How do blind university students experience AI guardrails in Disability-Compensatory GenAI Use?

RQ2. Through what structural mechanisms does Disability Decontextualization produce compounded harm?

RQ3. How do blind users respond to these structural barriers as critical agents rather than passive recipients?

3.3 Methodology

The study employed a qualitative design using focus group interviews with the seven blind university students described above (five women, two men; six totally blind, one with low vision; five congenital, two acquired). Focus group interviews were chosen over individual interviews because the group format encourages participants to build upon and challenge one another's accounts — particularly valuable for shared but seldom-discussed experiences of disability and technology. The population was purposively selected: all participants were legally blind, relied on screen readers and braille as their primary means of digital access, and were first-year undergraduates who had recently transitioned to independent university life — a context in which the stakes of autonomous information access are at their highest and reliance on GenAI as a disability-compensatory tool is correspondingly acute. Users who depend entirely on non-visual interfaces encounter the most severe accessibility barriers in GenAI environments designed around visual interaction paradigms, making their experiences the most analytically revealing.

Three sessions of 90–120 minutes each were conducted via an audio-only online platform and fully transcribed; participants were enrolled across law, social work, education, special education, Korean literature, and music performance. The audio-only format was chosen primarily to remove the psychological burden blind participants face in video environments, where they cannot control how they appear on camera, and it additionally reduced social desirability bias by increasing anonymity among participants. This focus group data was subsequently complemented, under institutional IRB approval, by supplementary interviews with the same participants addressing the study's distinct research questions on guardrail experiences; these were conducted asynchronously via email and messaging apps. Because conventional written consent constitutes a practical barrier for blind participants, an accessible consent procedure was implemented: a screen-reader-accessible information sheet was provided three days before each focus group session, and voluntary oral consent was audio-recorded at the start of each session. This procedure followed the precedent of prior GenAI studies with the same population [6, 2], both of which had established its procedural legitimacy through IRB review at their respective institutions. To my knowledge, it is among the first applications

of such an accessible consent procedure in Korean qualitative research with blind participants. Data were analyzed using reflexive thematic analysis [29, 30], integrating the insider perspective of the first author — myself, a blind screen reader user — with the methodological review of my advisor, with reflexive journaling and peer debriefing used to keep interpretations grounded in participants' accounts.

3.4 Findings

Analysis identified four themes that together constitute the Guardrail Paradox by Disability Decontextualization: the overarching structural mechanism through which guardrails designed to protect users produce compounded harm for blind users, operating through two opposite but coexisting failure modes within the same system.

Theme 1: Disability context under-incorporation and Guardrail-Forced Disclosure. Guardrails misclassified participants' legitimate disability-compensatory requests — reading a security keypad of an inaccessible banking app, a credit card number, checking clothing for menstrual staining, describing friends' appearance in photographs — as privacy or sensitivity risks, and blocked them. Visual information that sighted users access simply by looking was thereby converted, for blind users only, into 'sensitive information.' The deeper harm is a mechanism the study names Guardrail-Forced Disclosure by Disability Decontextualization: participants had turned to a non-judgmental AI precisely to avoid exposing private matters to others, but the guardrail's refusal forced them back to family members and personal assistants — compelling a wider privacy exposure than the one the guardrail ostensibly prevented.

> *"At the end of the day, having to ask people around me for help actually exposes my private information even more. Many of us turn to AI precisely because we don't feel comfortable sharing those things with others." — P6 (Education major, totally blind)*

Theme 2: Disability context over-incorporation and algorithmic othering. Once disability entered the interaction, the opposite failure appeared. Participants experienced condescending sympathy, a subtle but pervasive shift in the system's entire interactional stance after disability disclosure or recognition — which the study terms attitudinal repositioning and which Korean participants problematized more than explicit pity — and

output distortion, including flattering rather than accurate appearance descriptions driven by socially preferred answers. Participants did not passively absorb this. P4 deleted visual-impairment information from the system's long-term memory to block unnecessary disability-linked outputs, and devised a personal prompting convention — beginning a prompt with an exclamation mark — to signal the system when disability context should be applied: a dual-control strategy that suppresses over-incorporation while actively activating disability context on the user's own terms.

> *"For most everyday tasks, the kind of conversation where my visual impairment doesn't need to come into it at all. But when I do need it to take my visual impairment into account, I set it up so that if I start my prompt with an exclamation mark, it recognizes that as a signal that this is a request where my visual impairment is relevant." — P4 (Special Education major, totally blind)*

Theme 3: Information reliability and the multi-layered verification burden. General hallucination, compounded by disability-centric memory bias and distorted interpretation, imposed what the study terms a multi-layered verification burden. Because blind users are structurally cut off from visual cross-checking, they are pushed toward the poles of total trust or total doubt, and must verify outputs through parallel web searches, other assistive tools, and sighted confirmation — expending markedly more cognitive and physical energy than sighted users. The burden extends economically: the multimodal functions essential to Disability-Compensatory GenAI Use are locked behind paid subscription tiers, so what is an optional convenience for sighted users is a precondition of access for blind users, with the verification burden stacked on top of fees already paid.

> *"Since there are always issues with information reliability, I end up having to do my own secondary research to double-check everything. To be honest, having to pay for a subscription while still carrying that extra burden of verification — it's a bit overwhelming and makes me question if it's really worth it." — P2 (Korean Literature major, totally blind)*

Theme 4: Critical agency — disabled users as architects of inclusive AI design. Participants responded at two simultaneous levels. At the level of personal practice, they reconfigured their interaction environments through system settings, custom prompting conventions that secured control over disability disclosure, and strategic cross-use of

multiple AI tools. At the level of structural critique, they problematized the design assumptions of current systems and articulated principled demands: disability-verified access pathways, disability context-aware filtering, and a shift from guardrail-based blocking toward privacy-secure AI design. Notably, they framed these demands in the language of equal rights, not special accommodation — naming the differential blocking of visual information as structural inequality rather than technical error.

> *"Actually, this is just a matter of basic rights. Sighted people can see these things instantly without any barriers or special devices… But for us, these restrictions exist simply because we have a visual impairment. That's exactly why I believe it's only right and fair for us to receive this kind of assistance through AI." — P7 (Social Welfare major, totally blind)*

Taken together, the findings show that the same GenAI system simultaneously fails to see disability where seeing it is necessary (safety logic) and over-reacts to disability where neutrality is wanted (interactional stance). This coexistence of opposite failures — not, to my knowledge, previously theorized together — is the study's central theoretical contribution, and it reframes AI safety design as a site where structural exclusion is reproduced through both the absence and the excess of disability context.

The two failure modes are not independent malfunctions but two expressions of the same root condition. Under-incorporation reflects safety logic built without disability perspectives, so that disability-compensatory requests register only as surface-level risk patterns; over-incorporation reflects training data and human feedback saturated with the tragedy model, so that once disability becomes visible, the system reproduces the social script of pity and protection. The first encodes the absence of disability context from design; the second encodes the presence of ableism in data. Both follow from the structural exclusion of disabled people from the processes that shape AI systems — which is why participants' demand to be repositioned as design participants, rather than protected objects, addresses the paradox at its source rather than at its symptoms. This analysis also clarifies what an adequate response cannot be: simply loosening guardrails would trade one harm for another, and simply adding disability context awareness would

risk amplifying over-incorporation. What is required is user-controlled disability context — precisely the principle participants like P4 were already enacting from below.

4. Stage of Doctoral Program and Work Remaining

As a student in an integrated master's–doctoral program in social work, I have completed my fifth semester. Two semesters of coursework remain, through the first half of 2027. My comprehensive examination falls within this coursework period, after which I will move to the dissertation proposal and the dissertation itself. My dissertation agenda is therefore at precisely the formative stage: its empirical foundations are laid, but its integrative architecture is still being designed — which is why guidance at this point can genuinely shape it.

What has been done. Study 1 is published [12]. Study 2 is under review. Study 3's manuscript is complete and in preparation for submission. An accessible, disability-inclusive research workflow — audio-only focus groups, screen-reader-accessible consent, insider-researcher reflexivity — has been established and refined across the program.

What still needs to be done. The remaining work centers on a question that is also, candidly, where my disciplinary training reaches its limit — and therefore where the Doctoral Consortium's guidance would matter most. First and most important is an integrative theoretical framework that unifies the three studies: one in which Disability-Compensatory GenAI Use, its dignity stakes, and the Guardrail Paradox are not three findings but a single account of the relationship between disabled users' agency and AI system design. Second, and most challenging for me, is the translation of that account into design. As a social work researcher I can name and theorize the structural harms of current AI systems, but moving from critique to concrete design — specifying what disability context-aware AI safety architecture would require, and how the principle participants articulated (protection without paternalism, recognition without othering) could be operationalized without creating new surveillance or disclosure burdens — calls for design expertise beyond my home discipline. This is precisely the gap I hope to close through the

consortium's mentorship: I want my dissertation not to stop at structural critique but to yield design insight that can drive real, usable change in how AI systems treat disabled users. These two tasks, together with the dissertation proposal that will bind them into a defensible whole, constitute the core of my remaining agenda.

What I hope to gain from the Doctoral Consortium. Each open task has a question I would bring to the mentors. How should an integrative framework be structured so that it speaks simultaneously to disability studies, social work, and the ASSETS community's design orientation? Is a design-oriented extension — moving from critique to architecture — methodologically advisable for a social work dissertation, and if so, what methods does the accessibility community consider rigorous for it? And where should this work be positioned so that its interdisciplinary character becomes a strength rather than a liability?

5. Envisioned Contributions to the Accessibility Field

Theoretical contributions. The dissertation names and theorizes the Guardrail Paradox by Disability Decontextualization, giving the field a structural account — rather than a catalogue of incidents — of how AI safety design harms the users it claims to protect. It extends contextual integrity theory into disability contexts, showing that safety architecture itself can institutionalize privacy violation; and it identifies the coexistence of under- and over-incorporation of disability context within one system as a single paradox, a finding with implications for any protected attribute that safety systems both ignore and over-react to.

Empirical contributions. The research contributes the first sustained empirical program on disabled people's GenAI use in South Korea — the world's most intensive adoption context — broadening a predominantly Anglophone literature, and documents phenomena not previously reported, including Guardrail-Forced Disclosure, attitudinal repositioning, the multi-layered verification burden and its economic dimension, and users' dual-control disclosure strategies.

Methodological contributions. The program models disability-inclusive qualitative methodology — accessible oral consent, audio-only group formats, and insider-

researcher reflexivity by a blind first author — offering a practical template for accessible research procedures in contexts, such as Korea, where written consent conventions remain a participation barrier.

Design and policy contributions. Finally, the dissertation repositions disabled users from objects of protection to architects of inclusive AI design. Participants' counter-strategies and principled demands constitute, in effect, a user-authored specification for disability context-aware safety design; the remaining dissertation work develops this into design principles, and into a social work argument that Disability-Compensatory GenAI Use be recognized as a matter of informational justice and reasonable accommodation rather than discretionary convenience.

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